PARSHAT VAYERA · SHIUR READER

וַיַּשְׁכֵּם אַבְרָהָם בַּבֹּקֶר

THE SHACHARIT CLUB

"Own your morning. Elevate your life." The best-selling 5 AM Club says the first hour decides the whole day. Avraham Avinu got there first, and gave us a morning routine built on one word: standing.

RAV EITAN BENDAVID · KEHILLAT SHIVTEI YISRAEL, RA'ANANA · 5 MIN VIDEO · WATCH THE SHIUR →

THE CHALLENGE

Robin Sharma's *The 5 AM Club* argues that everyone should use the first hour of the morning to make the rest of the day "not just good, not just great, but perfect." Meanwhile many of us already have a sacred morning hour, Shacharit, and we rush through the pages and walk out the same people who walked in. We've been taught that davening means saying all the words. The Rav proposes something more.

AVRAHAM INSTITUTED SHACHARIT

BEREISHIT 19:27

וַיַּשְׁכֵּם אַבְרָהָם בַּבֹּקֶר אֶל־הַמָּקוֹם אֲשֶׁר־עָמַד שָׁם אֶת־פְּנֵי יְהוָה׃

Early in the morning, Avraham went to the place where he had stood before Hashem.

BERAKHOT 26B

אַבְרָהָם תִּקֵּן תְּפִלַּת שַׁחֲרִית, שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: "וַיַּשְׁכֵּם אַבְרָהָם בַּבֹּקֶר אֶל הַמָּקוֹם אֲשֶׁר עָמַד שָׁם", וְאֵין "עֲמִידָה" אֶלָּא תְּפִלָּה

Avraham instituted the morning prayer, as it says, "Avraham rose early in the morning to the place where he had stood," and "standing" means nothing other than prayer.

RAV KOOK: SHACHARIT MEANS STANDING FIRM

Why is prayer called *standing*? Rav Kook explains that Avraham established Shacharit because the morning is about **standing firm**. Before the day pulls us in every direction, with its obstacles, desires, and moral tests, we stand before HaKadosh Baruch Hu and ask:

- Who am I?
- What are my ideals, my dreams, my vision?

- What do I want to accomplish today?
- How will I stand strong against everything that pulls me off course?

> *"Tefilat Shacharit is that moment when we stand before HaKadosh Baruch Hu, recognizing who we are, and we ground ourselves for the day ahead."*
>
> —RAV EITAN BENDAVID

WHERE IS THERE ROOM TO VISUALIZE?

Sharma describes envisioning his "ideal performance for the day ahead" each morning. Most of Shacharit (Pesukei DeZimra, Birkot Kriyat Shema, the Amidah) is focused on Hashem. But some tefillot are open terrain for exactly this kind of thinking, like the one right after *HaMaavir Sheinah* in Birkot HaShachar:

BIRKOT HASHACHAR

וִיהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ... וְאַל תְּבִיאֵנוּ לֹא לִידֵי חֵטְא וְלֹא לִידֵי עֲבֵרָה וְעָוֹן... וְאַל תַּשְׁלֵט בָּנוּ יֵצֶר הָרָע...

וְדַבְּקֵנוּ בְּיֵצֶר הַטּוֹב וּבְמַעֲשִׂים טוֹבִים

May it be Your will... do not bring us to sin, or to transgression... do not let the yetzer hara rule over us... attach us to the good inclination and to good deeds.

TRY IT TOMORROW: 60 SECONDS

When you reach this Yehi Ratzon, slow down. Picture one moment from the coming day where you might stumble: a conversation, a temptation, a deadline. See yourself meeting it as the person you want to be. Then say the words.

> *"Join the 5 AM Club if you like. But hopefully we can also join the Shacharit Club: the club of Avraham Avinu."*
>
> —RAV EITAN BENDAVID

FOR THE SHABBAT TABLE

1. What would change if you thought of Shacharit as "standing firm" rather than "saying the words"?
2. Avraham returned to "the place where he had stood" after watching Sedom destroyed. Why might standing firm matter most after a hard day?
3. Which one challenge from this week would you want to "visualize" in tomorrow morning's Yehi Ratzon?